The 19th Degree – Grand Pontiff



The cordon is crimson, bordered with white, and worn from left to right. It teaches us that the zeal and ardor of a Grand Pontiff ought to be set off by the greatest purity of morals, perfect charity and beneficence. Where it crosses the breast, embroidered in gold are twelve stars and the Greek letters *Alpha* and *Omega* (AΩ). The stars upon it allude to the twelve gates of the New Jerusalem, the twelve signs of the Zodiac, the twelve fruits of the Tree of Life, the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve Apostles. The initials of the Apostles" names appear upon the gates and foundations of the New Jerusalem. The columns in the set of this degree also number twelve. In this degree there is also a fillet, or head band, of blue with twelve stars upon it which have the same significance as those on the cordon. It is the peculiar emblem of a Grand Pontiff because the slightest

contact with the earth will soil its spotless purity. Similarly, the least indiscretion will soil the exalted character which you have voluntarily assumed.

Another distinctive ornament in this degree is the breastplate of the High Priest of ancient Israel with twelve different gems embedded in a 4 × 3 matrix. Upon each gem is one of the initials of the twelve names (or attributes) of Deity mentioned in the ritual.

The jewel is an oblong square of solid gold, with the letter Aleph engraved on one side and Tau on the other. These letters are the first and last of the Hebrew alphabet as those upon the cordon are of the Greek. They should remind us of the love and veneration we owe to that Great Being, the source of all existence, the Alpha and Omega, the First and the Last. On His promises we rely with perfect confidence, in whose mercy and goodness we implicitly trust, and for the fulfillment of whose wise purposes we are content to wait.

DUTIES

Be content to labor for the future.
Serve the cause of truth with patience and industry.
Destroy error, falsehood and intolerance with truth, honesty, honor and charity.

LESSONS

Good will triumph over evil.
The human intellect cannot measure the designs of God.
If lived properly, this life is a bridge to eternal life.

FOR REFLECTION

Do you live your life so that it is a bridge to immortality?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Twelve columns around the Council Chamber, the Tracing Board of the New Jerusalem, the colors blue and gold, the Spirit of Masonry.

By exploring the origins of words in previous degrees, we have discovered hidden meaning and enlightenment. Here we have the same opportunity. The name, Grand Pontiff, does not refer to the leader of the Roman Catholic Church.

The word pontiff derives from two Latin words—*ponti*, meaning “bridge” and *facere*, “to make”; hence, pontiff means “bridge builder.” With this information, it is easy to see how the primary duty taught in the degree–labor for the future–and the lecture in *Morals and Dogma* relate directly to each other.

CEREMONY

The set is relatively simple. Blue and gold stars figure prominently. The fillet or headband worn by all the members is blue with gold stars as are the hangings on the set. Both are to remind us of that exalted character of a pontiff assumed by the candidate. This meaning is ascribed because blue is the color of the vault of heaven. Twelve columns are dispersed around the room: two in the East, two in the West, four in the North and four in the South. On the capital of each column is the first letter in English of each of the twelve tribes of Israel, emblematical of the human race. The columns also contain the signs of the Zodiac associated by Pike (p. 461) with each tribe as described by Jacob in Genesis 49. Under these are specific names of Deity which are descriptive of His attributes.

The theme of the degree is represented on the Tracing Boards drawing of the New Jerusalem descending from the sky as prophesied by St. John the Evangelist in the Revelation of Jesus Christ to him. This degree continues the use of symbolism derived from the vision of St. John which was begun in the 17th Degree. Of particular note is that the New Jerusalem is a city of golden buildings, without a temple; when good defeats evil forever, the presence and light of Deity will be everywhere. Hence, there is no need for a temple. Note too, the sparkling river which runs through the city. It is straddled by the roots of a large tree laden with fruits, leaves and blossoms. This, the Tree of Life, represents truth, the source of all the virtues which grow on the tree as fruit.

The candidate is received as a Knight Rose Croix who has served in the ranks of truth armed with faith, hope and charity; his special duties were to fight intolerance and oppression. He comes now to learn so that he may be prepared to serve the cause of truth and light. To be so, he must learn patience. He is made to

wait for approval to continue, a reference to the wait until the New Jerusalem appears upon the earth:

When sin no more the world shall blight
But endless day dethrone the night.

A Brother then leads the candidate twelve times around the room, stopping at the columns which contain the initials of the twelve Tribes of Israel, the signs of the zodiac and names of God. In the Book of Revelation only 12,000 of each of the tribes of Israel are saved from destruction (7:4–8). The chosen of the tribes of Israel represent the most righteous of the human race. At each column the meaning of the concept of the New Jerusalem is explained. Each s a special instruction on attributes of Deity and the goals, virtues and truths taught by Masonry. Following is a selection of these great ideas:

- *Light and truth, not error and darkness, are immortal. The reign of God is measured by eternity.*
- *Peace shall be the universal law for all the children of a common Father.*
- *Work, be patient and wait.*
- *Have in your heart a prayer to God and not hatred for your brother.*
- *Centuries are the moments of truth's twilight.*
- *The wanderings of none can be eternal, for then evil would be immortal.*
- *We are all blind; but when the divine light comes, we shall see and know.*
- *Our captivity by sin and sorrow are the means from God to purify the heart and ennoble the soul.*
- *The Great God made all and loves all.*
- *The true God is kind, indulgent, loving, forgiving, a benefactor, a friend and a father.*
- *Believe that all death is new life; hope for the rule of the law of love and light and wait patiently for the fulfillment of God's promises.*

Darkness and silence then surround the candidate—a practice included in the initiation ceremonies of the ancients. While in darkness verbal images of the final battle between good and evil, as envisioned in the Revelation to St. John, are presented.

In the Rubric, written in 1929 to supplement the ritual, a vision, occurring during a deep sleep brought about by the contents of the vial poured out by the Seventh Angel, is presented. The vision is an allegory and represents the final triumph of good over evil. The Spirit of Evil derides the human condition and philosophical pursuits. He tells us that man was created in truth but found error; man has and will continue to wander in the darkness, mere worms of the earth. If accepted, the fatalist philosophy he presents extinguishes hope from the heart of man. The Spirit of Masonry rebuts the Spirit of Evil with the Spirits of Immortality who call upon justice, tolerance, intelligence, truth, industry and gratitude to dispel the Spirits of darkness, injustice, intolerance, ignorance, superstition, indolence, ingratitude and intemperance. Upon awakening, the Pontiff leads all in prayer imploring God's aid in the battle against evil. The candidate is told to ever be prepared for this final battle wearing the armor of charity, hope and faith.

Two important questions are posed to the candidate. The questions contain the significant lessons of this degree: Will you obey God's law, trust in His goodness and be patient though the appointed time may seem to draw no nearer during your life, nor your labors and exertions produce any fruit? Will you be neither weary nor discouraged; satisfied to sow the seed, so those who come after you may reap? Thus, the candidate becomes a Pontiff faithful to God, his duty and himself, understanding these great lessons: each, man must act a bridge builder to the future, being a good example to his children, peers and brethren. A man's actions are a bridge to his own immortality and to the future of mankind. Masonry, too, is a bridge builder because it teaches the great truths of the past for the future.

In the final act, the newly initiated Pontiff symbolically destroys error, falsehood and intolerance with truth, honesty, honor and charity.

The last instruction concerns the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles, who are, to the Mason, the type of all those who have labored to reform, instruct and elevate mankind. The signs of the Zodiac are associated with the twelve tribes of Israel, but no further information is provided. Finally, the twelve great names and titles of Deity which, when translated from the Hebrew, are descriptive of the powers and qualities of Deity are related. They serve as both a summary of the concept of Deity presented in previous degrees and to be presented in future degrees. As well, they form part of a complex mystical anagram that is wholly esoteric, not even explained in the ritual itself.

LECTURE

In *Morals and Dogma* the lecture is comprised of two sections. The first elaborates the duties, virtues and qualities of a Pontiff and the influence of the past upon the present and the present upon the future. It draws from historical persons to illustrate this profound idea. The second section explains some basic information about that form of Hebrew mysticism known as the Kabbalah and associates the teachings of the Kabbalah with those of the Apocalypse.

Duties, Virtues and Qualities of a Grand Pontiff:

The true Mason labors for the benefit of those who are to come after him, and for the advancement and improvement of his race (p. 312).

All men who deserve to live, desire to survive their funerals, and to live afterward in the good that they have done mankind, rather than in the fading characters written in men's memories. Most men desire to leave some work behind them that may outlast their own day and brief generation. That is an instinctive impulse, given by God, and often found in the rudest human heart; the surest proof of the soul's immortality, and of the fundamental difference between man and the wisest brutes (p. 312).

To plant the trees that, after we are dead, shall shelter our children, is as natural as to love the shade of those our fathers planted (p. 312).

In his influences that survive him, man becomes immortal, before the general resurrection (p. 312).

Confucius still enacts the law for China; and the thoughts and ideas of Peter the Great govern Russia. Plato and the other great Sages of Antiquity still reign as the Kings of Philosophy, and have dominion over the human intellect. The great Statesmen of the Past still preside in the Councils of Nations (p. 313).

It is the Dead that govern. The Living only obey. And if the Soul sees, after death, what passes on this earth, and watches over the welfare of those it loves, then must its greatest happiness consist in seeing the current of its beneficent influences widening out from age to age, as rivulets widen into rivers, and aiding to shape the destinies of individuals, families, States, the World; and its bitterest punishment, in seeing its evil influences causing mischief and misery, and cursing and afflicting men, long after the frame it dwelt in has become dust, and when both name and memory are forgotten (p. 315).

Thus we obey the dead; and thus shall the living, when we are dead, for weal or woe, obey us. The Thoughts of the Past are the Laws of the Present and the Future. That which we say and do, if its effects last not beyond our lives, is unimportant. That which shall live when we are dead, as part of the great body of law enacted by the dead, is the only act worth doing, the only Thought worth speaking. The desire to do something that shall benefit the world, when neither praise nor obloquy will reach us where we sleep soundly in the grave, is the noblest ambition entertained by man (p. 316).

Knowing the slow processes by which the Deity brings about great results, [the Mason] does not expect to reap as well as sow, in a single lifetime. It is the inflexible fate and noblest destiny, with rare exceptions, of the great and good, to work, and let others reap the harvest of their labors (p. 316).

So it is with the aggregate of Human endeavor. As the invisible particles of vapor combine and coalesce to form the mists and clouds that fall in rain on thirsty continents, and bless the great green forests and wide grassy prairies, the

waving meadows and the fields by which men live; as the infinite myriads of drops that the glad earth drinks are gathered into springs and rivulets and rivers, to aid in leveling the mountains and elevating the plains, and to feed the large lakes and restless oceans; so all Human Thought, and Speech and Action, all that is done and said and thought and suffered upon the Earth combine together, and flow onward in one broad resistless current toward those great results to which they are determined by the will of God (p. 320).

Be patient, therefore, my Brother, and wait!
The issues are with God: To do,
Of right belongs to us.

Therefore faint not, nor be weary in well–doing! Be not discouraged at men's apathy, nor disgusted with their follies, nor tired of their indifference! Care not for returns and results; but see only what there s to do, and do it, leaving the results to God! Soldier of the Cross! Sworn Knight of Justice, Truth, and Toleration! Good Knight and True! be patient and work! (p. 320).